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Homework 2: Achieving Childhood Dreams Lecture Response

Randy Pausch's lecture, "Achieving Your Childhood Dreams," is a beautiful and profound meditation on life, delivered under extraordinary circumstances. Despite having ten tumors in his liver and a prognosis of only months to live, Pausch chose not to focus on his impending death, but on the joy of his life's journey and the lessons he could leave behind. His lecture plays as a "head fake", while it seems to be about achieving specific goals, it is actually a guide on how to lead life with integrity, enthusiasm, and gratitude.

What resonates with me deeply was Pausch's perspective on obstacles, which he famously terms "brick walls." He states that "the brick walls are there for a reason. The brick walls are not there to keep us out. The brick walls are there to give us a chance to show how badly we want something". His reframing of failure and rejection as a test of dedication rather than a definitive stop is incredibly motivating. He viewed the obstacles he faced, like being rejected by Disney Imagineering, as opportunities to prove his resolve rather than letting them keep him stuck.

Equally moving was how at the very end of the lecture, you find the entire talk was not just for the audience in the room, but also a legacy for his three children. This act of using his final "good health" months to create a roadmap for his kids is a powerful testament to his character. This reminded me a lot of my own father who has a rare genetic disorder that causes tumors to grow on nerve tissue and has always strived to embody kindness while teaching my sister and I to be grateful for every lesson, good or bad, because it means we have learned.

I also found myself identifying with Pausch's "Tigger versus Eeyore" analogy, which is a simple yet vital choice that defines one's quality of life and very much like my father. Pausch's decision to remain a "Tigger", full of child-like wonder and fun even while facing terminal cancer, is a convicting reminder that we cannot change the "cards we are dealt," only how we "play the hand".

Ultimately, this lecture was a masterclass in gratitude. With examples like thanking his mentors for "Dutch-uncleing" him when he was arrogant, he continuously demonstrated that no one achieves their dreams alone. By the end of the lecture, it is clear that "if you lead your life the right way, the karma will take care of itself. The dreams will come to you". His story is a reminder to work hard and tell the truth all while always keep a bit of that child-like wonder alive.

